

FRANCIS "GABBY" GABRESKI

FRANCIS "GABBY" GABRESKI (1919–2002) was one of only seven pilots to achieve ace status both in World War II and the Korean War. Born in a small town in Pennsylvania, the son of Polish immigrants, Gabreski fell in love with flying as a boy in 1932, when he was taken to see Jimmy Doolittle win the Thompson Trophy Race in a GeeBee Sportster. In 1940 he applied to join the Army Air Corps but, awkward and nervous, was almost washed out of flight training, narrowly qualifying in a last-chance "elimination flight."

Sent to fight in Europe, he flew with a Polish squadron of the RAF before becoming a member of the USAF's 56th Fighter Group. Flying P-47 Thunderbolts, he recorded 28 kills before being shot down and made a prisoner of war in the summer of 1944.

Gabreski was in his thirties when the Korean War gave him a second bite at air combat.

Leading 51st Fighter-Interceptor Wing based at Suwon, he was credited with shooting down six and a half MiGs (one shared with another pilot). Like many pilots who had fought in World War II, Gabreski disdained new-fangled technology such as radar-controlled gunsights. An inveterate gum-chewer, he would pick some gum out of his mouth as he entered combat and stick it to his Sabre's windshield to line up his shot. His natural ability never let him down.

FAMED ACE

Gabreski's ace status made him famous – he was invited to meet the president – but he always remained at heart just a small-town boy in love with flying.



interdiction missions. The aircraft were mostly of World War II vintage – Mustangs used in a ground-attack role, US Navy Corsairs operating from carriers, B-26 and B-29 bombers – along with F-80 Shooting Star jets almost as old. In the absence of any serious opposition, these well-tried airplanes ruled the air. But when China entered the conflict, it brought with it the state-of-the-art MiG-15, and Korea became the first war of the jet age.

Jet combat

The first shooting down of one jet aircraft by another took place in November 1950, when American pilot Lieutenant Russell J. Brown, flying an F-80, downed a Chinese MiG-15. Operating from safe bases around Antung in Chinese Manchuria, the jets began to intercept US bomber missions, threatening to deny the Americans the air superiority they had previously enjoyed. In December 1950, the United States sent in the F-84 Thunderjet as a ground-attack aircraft, and its latest fighter, the F-86 Sabre, to take on the MiGs.

The Sabres were deployed on offensive sweeps, engaging the communist jets over the Yalu River in northwest Korea, and effectively preventing enemy aircraft from interfering

with American air operations further south.

There were strange echoes of World War I in the Korean conflict. As on the Western Front in 1914–18, the most important function of air power was to support ground troops engaged in a grim and desperate war of attrition. But once again, it was the fighter pilots and their contest for air superiority that grabbed the headlines. The duel between MiG-15s and Sabres in "MiG Alley" over the Yalu was awarded legendary status as a classic of aerial combat even while it happened.

The MiG pilots were anonymous, generally operating in formations more than 50 strong. The far less numerous Sabre pilots were a self-conscious elite, aggressive, eager for action, and intensely competitive. Not since World War I had the pursuit of ace status – the famous five kills –

had such importance. Returning from the mission on which he recorded his fifth kill, pilot Frederick "Boots" Blesse claims that he said a prayer: "Lord, if you have to take me while I'm over here, don't do it today. Let me get back and tell someone I finally got number five." There was competition for scores not only among individual pilots but between the two Sabre-equipped formations, the 4th and 51st fighter-interceptor wings. After a mission on which he shot down two MiGs, Blesse was embraced by his commander, Colonel Harrison Thyng of 4th wing: "Damn, Boots," said Colonel Thyng, "it's about time somebody in this wing was the leading ace."

Many of the American pilots were World War II veterans – the average age of pilots in Korea was around 30, which would have been old for an airman in 1941–45. The war's "top gun," Captain Joseph McConnell, conformed to the classic Korean War profile – 30 years old, World War II veteran (although as a navigator on B-24s). Aces such as James Jabara and "Gabby" Gabreski had been fighter pilots in the earlier conflict. They were as eager to repeat or improve on earlier achievements as the younger pilots were to make their mark for the first time. They had a maximum of 100 missions to show what they were worth before being transferred back to the United States.

READY FOR ACTION

US Marines disembark from Piasecki HRP-1 tandem-rotor transport helicopters during an early air assault operation. The HRP-1, which first flew in 1947, was known as the "Flying Banana" because of the distinctive shape of its fuselage.

